A Judge Hits Pause on the Giant Arch

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A judge pressed pause on a giant arch planned for Washington, D.C. just moments after it won approval. Just before midnight on Thursday, District Court Judge Tanya Chutkan blocked any construction work for 14 days. The order came at the request of the governments of Washington, D.C., and Virginia. The proposed arch would stand 250 feet tall in Memorial Circle, a traffic island on the bridge that links the Lincoln Memorial to Arlington National Cemetery. Work was planned to run 20 hours a day, year-round, for two to three years. In a 33-page **opinion**, Judge Chutkan wrote that the local governments are likely to be harmed by the construction, noting that traffic problems would begin as soon as building started. Less than two hours earlier, the National Capital Planning Commission had approved the arch in an 8-to-4 vote. The commission heard nearly eight hours of **testimony**, and about 131 people had signed up to speak. Most speakers opposed the plan. Critics said the arch would block an important view, add risk to the area's busy **airspace**, and show disrespect to service members buried at nearby Arlington National Cemetery. They also questioned whether the project is legal and how much it would cost, which the administration has not confirmed. Only a handful of speakers supported the arch, including two Republican members of Congress. Supporters on the commission described the arch as a **tribute** to the nation and to those who served. They argued that Congress had already **authorized** the project in 1925, when it approved two tall columns for the same spot that were never built. Lawsuits challenging the arch are still moving through the courts, including one filed by Vietnam War veterans and an architectural historian, and another filed jointly by D.C. and Virginia. For now, the arch is on hold.

Word Treasure

testimony -- Testimony is what people say in a formal meeting or hearing to share their views.

authorized -- Authorized means officially allowed by a law or by someone in charge.

tribute -- A tribute is something created to honor people and show respect for them.

airspace -- Airspace is the sky above an area where airplanes fly.

opinion -- An opinion is a judge's written explanation of a court decision.

Background you need

Memorial Circle sits on the bridge between the Lincoln Memorial and Arlington National Cemetery, a place where the country honors people who served.

A triumphal arch is a large monument built to celebrate a nation and the people who served it, and this spot was set aside long ago for a tall memorial structure that was never built.

That is why the arch was proposed here: supporters see it as a tribute at a place already tied to national memory.

Because the circle is a busy traffic island next to a cemetery and a famous memorial, any big building project there raises questions about traffic, views, and respect for the site.

Break it down

LEAD: A judge pressed pause on a giant arch planned for Washington, D.C., just moments after it won approval.

KEY EVENT: District Court Judge Tanya Chutkan blocked any construction work for 14 days.

+- WHO: Judge Tanya Chutkan, at the request of the governments of Washington, D.C., and Virginia.

+- WHEN: Just before midnight on Thursday, less than two hours after the National Capital Planning Commission approved the arch.

+- WHY: In a 33-page opinion, she wrote that the local governments are likely to be harmed by the construction, noting that traffic problems would begin as soon as building started.

THE PLAN: The proposed arch would stand 250 feet tall in Memorial Circle, a traffic island on the bridge that links the Lincoln Memorial to Arlington National Cemetery, with work planned to run 20 hours a day, year-round, for two to three years.

THE APPROVAL: The National Capital Planning Commission approved the arch in an 8-to-4 vote after nearly eight hours of testimony, with about 131 people signed up to speak.

OPPOSITION: Most speakers opposed the plan, saying it would block an important view, add risk to the area's busy airspace, and show disrespect to service members buried at nearby Arlington National Cemetery, and questioning whether the project is legal and how much it would cost, which the administration has not confirmed.

SUPPORT: Only a handful of speakers supported the arch, including two Republican members of Congress, and supporters on the commission described it as a tribute to the nation and to those who served, arguing that Congress had already authorized the project in 1925, when it approved two tall columns for the same spot that were never built.

OPEN QUESTION: Lawsuits challenging the arch are still moving through the courts, including one filed by Vietnam War veterans and an architectural historian, and another filed jointly by D.C. and Virginia, so for now the arch is on hold.

Why it matters

The pause affects a prominent memorial landscape, daily traffic, and busy airspace near Arlington National Cemetery, and the continuing lawsuits will help decide whether a major new monument can be built there.

Test what you remember

1. How long did Judge Tanya Chutkan block any construction work on the arch?

- (A) 33 days
- (B) 7 days
- (C) 14 days
- (D) Two to three years

2. Where would the proposed arch stand?

- (A) Inside Arlington National Cemetery
- (B) In downtown Washington, D.C.
- (C) In Memorial Circle, a traffic island on the bridge that links the Lincoln Memorial to Arlington National Cemetery
- (D) At the Lincoln Memorial

3. How tall would the proposed arch stand?

- (A) 500 feet
- (B) 250 feet
- (C) 350 feet
- (D) 150 feet

4. How did the National Capital Planning Commission vote on the arch?

- (A) 8-to-2
- (B) 10-to-4
- (C) 8-to-4
- (D) 4-to-8

5. Who asked the judge to block construction of the arch?

- (A) Two Republican members of Congress
- (B) Vietnam War veterans and an architectural historian
- (C) The governments of Washington, D.C., and Virginia
- (D) The National Capital Planning Commission

6. What did supporters argue about Congress and the project in 1925?

- (A) The National Capital Planning Commission had approved the arch in 1925
- (B) Congress had already authorized the project in 1925, when it approved two tall columns for the same spot that were never built
- (C) The arch had already been built in 1925
- (D) Congress had rejected the project in 1925

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: C 3: B 4: C 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Critics and most speakers at the hearing: They opposed the arch, saying it would block an important view, add risk to the area's busy airspace, and show disrespect to service members buried at nearby Arlington National Cemetery, and they questioned whether the project is legal and how much it would cost.

2. Supporters of the arch: They described the arch as a tribute to the nation and to those who served, and argued that Congress had already authorized the project in 1925, when it approved two tall columns for the same spot that were never built.

3. The governments of Washington, D.C., and Virginia: They asked the judge to block construction; the judge wrote in her 33-page opinion that they are likely to be harmed by the construction, with traffic problems beginning as soon as building started.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):